

If you are importing food into Australia for sale, you have legal responsibilities to take steps to assure yourself that the food is safe for human consumption and meets Australia's biosecurity import conditions, food standards and other import requirements.

This guide explains the steps importers need to follow to export food to Australia that is intended for sale.

It helps importers meet:

- Australian import laws
- the Australian New Zealand Food Standards Code
- the Country of Origin Food Labelling Information Standard
- biosecurity and food safety requirements.

Before you import

Before importing food, check our [Biosecurity Import Conditions system](#) (BICON) for biosecurity import conditions that may apply to your food.

All biosecurity requirements must be met before the [Imported Food Inspection Scheme](#) (IFIS) requirements apply.

Use BICON to determine whether your food can be imported into Australia

- any treatments, certificates or biosecurity conditions apply
- what you must do before your food arrives.

Food imported for sale in Australia must be safe and comply with the [Country of Origin food Labelling Information Standard](#) and the [Australia New Zealand Food Standards Code](#) (the Code).

To source safe and compliant food, seek assurances from your supplier that the food:

- has been produced under a food safety system that effectively identifies and controls foodborne hazards of concern
- complies with compositional requirements (e.g. only contains ingredients or additives permitted for use in Australia)
- is not fortified with vitamins and minerals, unless permitted
- only contains permitted agricultural and veterinary residues within allowable limits (MRLs specified in [Schedule 20](#) & [Schedule 21](#) of the Code)
- meets the microbiological and contaminant limits in [Schedule 27](#) and [Schedule 19](#) respectively of the Code
- is not a prohibited plant or fungi and does not contain as an ingredient a prohibited plant or fungi listed in [Schedule 23](#) of the Code
- has not been irradiated or does not contain ingredients that have been irradiated unless expressly permitted under [Standard 1.5.3](#) of the Code

- is correctly labelled, including declaration of [mandatory allergens](#) (unless you are labelling the food after it arrives in Australia before you distribute it for sale or prior to the time of inspection under the Imported Food Inspection Scheme)
- packaging is safe to use with the food product and compliant with [Standard 3.2.2](#) of the Code
- is a permitted [novel food](#) under Standards 1.1.1 and 1.5.1 [Schedule 25 – section 2](#) of the Code.

You can verify safety and compliance by asking your supplier for:

- evidence of food safety certification
- results of product testing
- ingredient information documents
- product specification sheets and sample labels.

Once all biosecurity requirements have been met, food may be referred to the [Imported Food Inspection Scheme](#) (IFIS) for inspection and testing.

Check the [food safety requirements](#) in BICON by:

- typing the goods description into the ‘quick search’ field, clicking on ‘search’. You can also search by tariff code or scientific name
- opening the relevant food safety case listed under ‘Search Results’
Note: the food safety requirements are colour identifiable by pink shaded titles
- checking the case description to ensure you have selected the right case
- answering the questions that apply to the food you intend to import.

On arrival

You must lodge details of your food imported for sale in a [Full Import Declaration](#).

Use the [Cargo Online Lodgement System \(COLS\)](#) to submit your documentation.

BICON will advise what documentation is required. This may include a/an:

We issue a [Food Control Certificate](#) (FCC) to let you know your imported food needs to be inspected and if any tests apply.

The food to be inspected must remain on hold. You cannot distribute it.

See our [Inspecting and testing imported food](#) for further information.

If your food needs to be tested, the Food Control Certificate will instruct you to nominate a laboratory. The laboratory must be an appointed analyst under the IFIS.

- Check what tests are listed on your Food Control Certificate.
- Select a laboratory that can perform most of the required tests from the list of [appointed laboratories](#).

- Contact the laboratory to confirm they:
 - can perform the tests required on your food sample
 - can sub-contract one or more tests to another laboratory if you have multiple tests required on more than one food sample
 - service the area in which your food is located
 - will accept your nomination.
- Complete the [Laboratory nomination form](#) and send it to the laboratory. You may choose a laboratory for one consignment only or for all future consignments, this is called an ‘ongoing nomination’. See [Book a laboratory for food testing](#) for more information on how to nominate a laboratory and about ongoing nominations.
- The laboratory will confirm the nomination by returning the form back to us.

Note: If analytical tests apply you cannot book an IFIS inspection until you have nominated a laboratory and they have accepted your nomination.

Food importers must pay the appointed analyst for any laboratory testing required.

If your food has been referred for a labelling and visual inspection only, without analytical testing, you will need to book an inspection with us. While you can book an in-person inspection, most labelling and visual inspections can be conducted virtually, saving you time.

Refer to [Inspecting and testing imported food](#) for details on eligibility and how to book a virtual inspection.

- You must be registered to take part in virtual inspections.
- To register your business for virtual inspections, email your expression of interest to importedfood-postinspection@aff.gov.au.

If your food requires inspection and testing:

- Book an inspection with us once a laboratory advises you they have accepted your nomination.
- To book your in-person inspection, complete and submit the request via the [Portal](#).

Inspection and testing fees

Inspections of imported food intended for sale are cost recovered. See our [charging guidelines](#).

Food Import Compliance Agreement

Food importers can enter into a Food Import Compliance Agreement (FICA) with us if they have a documented food safety management system. This is instead of having your food inspected and tested under the IFIS.

We regulate FICAs under an audit arrangement with you where we assess the effectiveness of your documented food safety management system.

Find out more about [FICAs](#).

Keep records

You must keep records showing where your food imports are from.

Keep a record of:

- contact details of your suppliers or customers
- descriptions of the food and batch or lot identification
- transaction dates
- how much food you've received or will be supplied.

Stay informed

Check our [Imported Food Notices](#) for updates on imported food requirements.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/goods/food/how>